

Ararat Gocmen

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Labor, Finance, Migration, Entrepreneurship

DOCTORAL STUDIES

University College London (UCL) – PhD in Economics

2027 (expected)

Dissertation: “Essays in Labor and Finance”

Supervisors and references:

Christian Dustmann
Professor of Economics
University College London
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Uta Schönberg
Professor of Economics
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Saleem Bahaj
Professor of Economics and Finance
University College London
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Clara Martínez-Toledano
Assistant Professor of Finance
Imperial College London
Business School Building, 4.03a
South Kensington Campus
London, UK SW7 2AZ
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PRIOR EDUCATION

University College London and Queen Mary University of London

2021

MA in History of Political Thought and Intellectual History, distinction

University College London

2020

MSc in Economics, distinction

Princeton University

2017

AB in History, *summa cum laude*

PERSONAL INFORMATION

Citizenship: United States of America

Languages: English, Armenian, Turkish (native); French, Italian (intermediate); German (beginner)

Skills: Stata, MATLAB, Python, R, SQL

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

ROCKWOOL Foundation Berlin (RFBerlin) – Research Fellow

2026-present

Centre for Research and Analysis of Migration (CReAM) – Research Officer

2020-present

BlackRock – Analyst, Portfolio Analytics Group

2017-2019

European Roma Rights Centre – Legal Intern

2015

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

ECON0121 – Economic History: BSc, Professor Ramin Nassehi

2024-2026

ECON0062 – Topics in Labor Economics: MSc, Professor Christian Dustmann

2023-2024

ECON0050 – Economics of the Public Sector: BSc, Professors Silvia Dal Bianco and Lucas Conwell

2022-2023

AWARDS, GRANTS, HONORS & SCHOLARSHIPS

Best Paper Award in Labor and Public Economics, Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society-China	2026
Stone PhD Scholarship, UCL Stone Centre	2025
Peggy and Richard Musgrave Prize for Best Paper, International Institute of Public Finance	2025
Adam Smith Fellowship, Mercatus Center	2024
External Research Support Grant (£50,000), UCL Stone Centre	2023
Top-Performing MSc Student Prize in Economics, UCL	2020
Outstanding MSc Dissertation Prize in Economics, UCL	2020
Marshall Scholarship	2019
Phi Beta Kappa Society	2017
Gamma Kappa Alpha National Italian Honor Society	2017
Laurence Hutton Prize in History, Princeton University	2017
Walter Phelps Hall Senior Thesis Prize in European History, Princeton University	2017
André Maman Senior Thesis Prize in French History, Princeton University	2017
Lawrence Stone and Shelby Cullom Davis Prize in History, Princeton University	2016
Shapiro Prize for Academic Excellence, Princeton University	2015

INVITED PRESENTATIONS

2026 – Centre for the Analysis of Taxation Capital Gains Tax Workshop, Norwegian Centre for Taxation Seminar, RFBerlin Nizza Monferrato Workshop, UCL SPP Migration Cluster and ETH Immigration Policy Lab Workshop on Immigration and Political Behavior, Armenian Economic Association Annual Meeting, CSEF-CEPR Conference on Labor and Finance, Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society-China, World Inequality Conference, Migration and Organizations Conference, UCL Centre for Finance Research Half Day, RFBerlin Migration Forum

2025 – ESMT Berlin and IWH Labor and Finance Group Fall Conference, CEPR Paris Symposium, UCL Applied Microeconomics PhD Research Day, NBER Public Economics Program Fall Meeting, Northern Finance Association Annual Meeting, RFBerlin-CReAM Workshop, European Economic Association Annual Congress, NBER Summer Institute Household Finance, Eleventh Conference of the Society for the Study of Economic Inequality, Armenian Economic Association Annual Meeting, EU Tax Observatory and IEB Workshop on the Economics of Taxation, European Association of Young Economists Annual Meeting, Lake District Workshop in Corporate Finance, RFBerlin Migration Forum

2024 – Asian and Australasian Society of Labor Economics Conference, Madrid Public Economics Workshop, RFBerlin-CReAM Summer Workshop

INVITED PROGRAMS

UBC Stone Centre visit	2026
MIT Stone Centre visit	2026
NBER Entrepreneurship Research Boot Camp	2025
UC Berkeley Stone Center Summer Institute	2023

WORKING PAPERS

“Private Capital Markets and Inequality” – Revise and Resubmit, *American Economic Review* ([SSRN](#), [VoxEU](#))

with Clara Martínez-Toledano (Imperial) and Vrinda Mittal (UNC-Chapel Hill)

This paper examines how expanding private capital markets contribute to rising economic inequalities in the US. We show that the share of early-stage financing raised from US high-net-worth individuals (HNWIs) tripled from 2004 to 2022. Exploiting the expansion of the qualified small business stock (QSBS) long-term capital gains tax exclusion, we find that HNWIs’ investments made startups 5.6% more likely to stay private. Counterfactual simulations reveal that HNWIs’ excess returns on early-stage investments explain 26% of the growth in the top 0.5% wealth share over 2010-2022. Finally, investor entry increased incumbents’ returns and encouraged further investments, generating a self-reinforcing feedback loop between private capital market growth and inequality.

WORKS IN PROGRESS

“Immigration and Firm Investment” – Job Market Paper

Standard models of immigration predict that native earnings recover as firms expand their capital stocks in response to the labor supply shock. I show that this adjustment depends on firms' access to credit. I embed a costly state verification friction into a neoclassical model of the labor market effects of immigration: more indebted firms face a higher external finance premium, so they expand their capital stocks by less, and their capital-labor ratios fall by more. I test this prediction in the context of Germany during the 2010s, combining a shift-share instrument for regional immigration shocks with firm-level variation in pre-shock leverage. Higher-leverage firms hired immigrants at the same rate as lower-leverage firms but increased their capital stocks and borrowing by less. Consistent with the resulting decline in their capital-labor ratios, the earnings of their native workers fell by more.

“Immigration and Labor Market Tightness” – Presented at the [Sixth World Labor Conference](#), 2025

with Thomas Cornelissen (Essex), Christian Dustmann (UCL), and Uta Schönberg (HKU)

This paper examines how the effects of immigration on native workers' employment and wages depend on initial labor market tightness. We first predict, based on a search-and-matching model, that the effect of immigration on native employment is less negative in an initially tighter labor market, while its effect on native wages is more negative. We then test these predictions in the context of Germany during the 2010s, when every annual inflow of immigrants entered in tighter conditions than the previous year's. Comparing the initially slackest and tightest local labor markets, we find that initial tightness attenuated immigration's negative employment effects but amplified its negative wage effects, with these heterogeneities sharper for the lower-wage natives more exposed to competition from immigrants.

PREDOCTORAL RESEARCH

“Before Class Struggle: Inequality in European Political and Economic Thought from More to Marx” – Presented at the London Inequality Workshop, 2023

“*Hay, Yabancı, Mensch*: National Difference and Multinational Society in the Political Thought of Armenian Workers from Turkey in Postwar Germany” – Presented at the Princeton University Department of Near Eastern Studies Turkish Language Talk, 2022

“Otto Bauer's 'National-Evolutionary Politics': Cultural Nationalism as Socialist Strategy in Hapsburg Austria” – Presented at the Twelfth Annual London Graduate Conference in the History of Political Thought, 2021

“The Age of Extremes in Colonial Context: The Mass Politics of Left and Right in the Department of Alger, 1935-1939” – [Senior Thesis](#), Princeton University, 2017

“Reinterpreting the Volcker Disinflation: the Anti-Inflationary Resolve (or Lack Thereof) of the Federal Open Market Committee during Paul Volcker's First Year of Chairmanship, August 1979-July 1980” – Junior Paper, Princeton University, 2016

“Workers' Demonstrations and Liberals' Condemnations: the Italian Liberal Press's Coverage of General Strikes, Factory Occupations, and Workers' Self-Defense Groups during the Rise of Fascism, 1919-1922” – *Chicago Journal of History*, [Issue 6](#), 2016, pp. 29-43.